

Sebastian Esteva

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Dear Human Computer Lab Team,

Clicking “Wake up LeLamp” sparked a small burst of joy in an otherwise exhausting application process. So did your entire website. And I have submitted a lot of applications for this fall...

What you are building sits at the exact intersection I have been working toward my entire career. My undergraduate degree is in Biomechanical Engineering at Stanford, yet I’m also getting a Master’s in Communication. A combination which has confused so many, yet I think I finally have an answer to give all those confused recruiters— your website and mission. Let me explain.

I chose biomechanical engineering because I wanted to understand how the physical world (weights, radiation, etc.) impacts the human. The outside world, in.

I chose communications because I wanted to understand how humans perceive and understand the world, from the inside out.

And by combining those two knowledge bases, work towards building the perfect synchrony between the two.

Human-robot interaction, character robots, new ways for people to form attachment to technology — that is the future of communication. It is also exactly what you are building. That is where I want to live, and that is where the Human Computer Lab stands.

Your manifesto hit me in a way I did not expect. The frustration that human-computer interfaces have barely evolved in forty years — I feel that deeply. Especially with an aging grandfather who can barely use his computer, since it’s designed for young minds and eyes.

And your focus is on creating chaos, and carving order out of it is how I grew up, as my parents are both artists. They live in the chaos, and find it beautiful. And their artwork gives those who crave order a little window into the chaos, so we can enjoy it. I want to do that, but through technology.

I recently won “Most Innovative Solution” at a d.school hackathon hosted by the Stanford Wu Tsai Human Performance Alliance. It was for a simple concept, which arose from three hours of talking with the end user, a gentleman who had lost arm function after a stroke. And I attribute every bit of that win to trying to understand the human first, and then letting my technical expertise scope and craft a solution.

That is the kind of engineer I want to be. Not someone who just wants to get the CAD done, but rather a person who wants to build for people. I am not just a mechanical engineering intern or human psychology communications expert; rather, I am a beautiful combo of both.

I really hope how much I want this comes through. I’d love to at least chat.

Sincerely,

Sebastian Esteva